

A Red Team Perspective Iran's Military Strategy Vis-a-vis the United States

“ . . . The United States and Israel may be contemplating military operations against Iran, as per recent media reports . . . A week-long combined air and ground maneuver has just concluded in five of the southern and western provinces of Iran, mesmerizing foreign observers, who have described as ‘spectacular’ the massive display of high-tech, mobile operations, including rapid-deployment forces relying on squadrons of helicopters, air lifts, missiles, as well as hundreds of tanks and tens of thousands of well-coordinated personnel using live munitions.

Learning from both the 2003 Iraq war and Iran's own previous experiences of the 1980-88 war with Iraq and the 1987-88 confrontation with US forces in the Persian Gulf, Iranians have focused on the merits of a fluid and complex defensive strategy that seeks to take advantage of certain weaknesses in the US military superpower while maximizing the precious few areas where they may have the upper hand, e.g.; numerical superiority in ground forces, guerrilla tactics, terrain, etc.

Any US attack on Iran will likely be met first and foremost by missile counter-attacks engulfing the southern Persian Gulf states playing host to US forces, as well as any other country—e.g., Azerbaijan, Iraq, or Turkey allowing their territory or airspace to be used against Iran. The rationale for this strategy is precisely to pre-warn Iran's neighbors of the dire consequences, with potential debilitating impacts on their economies for a long time, should they become accomplices of foreign invaders of Iran.

Another key element of Iran's strategy is to “increase the arch of crisis” in places such as Afghanistan and Iraq, where it has considerable influence, to undermine the United States' foothold in the region, hoping to create a counter-domino effect wherein instead of gaining inside Iran, the US would actually lose territory partly as a result of thinning its forces and military ‘overreach.’

Iran's counter-psychological warfare, on the other hand, seeks to take advantage of the ‘death-fearing’ American soldiers who typically lack a strong motivation to fight wars not necessarily in defense of the homeland. A war with Iran would definitely require establishing the draft in the US, without which it could not possibly protect its flanks in Afghanistan and Iraq.

There is a sense of national-security siege in Iran these days, in light of a tightening “security belt” by the US benefiting from military bases in Iraq, Turkey, Azerbaijan, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, as well as Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Bahrain, Oman, and the island-turned garrison of Diego Garcia. From Iran's vantage point, the US, having won the Cold War, has turned into a ‘leviathan unhinged’ capable of manipulating and subverting the rule of international law and the United Nations with impunity, thus requiring a sophisticated Iranian strategy of deterrence, that, in the words of certain Iranian media pundits, would even include the use of nuclear weapons . . .”

*—Excerpts from Kaveh L. Afrasiabi (Tehran University), “How Iran Will Fight Back,”
cited in Asia Times Online Ltd., 2004.*